occupation, are duty-bound to fight. Abdullah Azzam, bin Laden's mentor and a founder of Lashkar's parent organization, is the man most responsible for this modern twist. He declared in a highly influential fatwa that fighting to expel foreign occupiers from all Muslim lands was 'the most important of all compulsory duties.'[5] Classical jihadis also believe that any land ever controlled by Muslims is Muslim land. In this light, even a country such as Spain is in need of 'liberation.' Because pan-Islamist jihadis cannot fight everywhere at once it is necessary to make choices about where to focus their energies. Geography or the popularity of a particular front may play a role in the decision-making process, such that if a snapshot of an actor at war were taken it might be difficult to distinguish between a nation-oriented and umma-oriented jihad. The key distinction is that those motivated by nation-oriented Islamism theoretically would cease their violent activities once the specific territory for which they are fighting was liberated. Classical jihadis may focus on a specific piece of territory, but theoretically would not cease their activities once it was liberated so long as other Muslim lands were occupied.

While classical jihadis will fight against the US on open fronts, and may prioritize action on those fronts for any number of reasons, their main focus is not American-centric. This distinguishes them from global jihadis, who are characterized by a specifically anti-American agenda. Al-Qaeda pioneered the idea of prioritizing the fight against America, known as the 'far enemy' to distinguish it from local Muslim regimes or the 'near enemy'. In addition to an American-centric focus, this doctrine promoted a global view of warfare that entailed attacking US interests anywhere in the world. Global jihadism expanded after 9/11 to include military confrontation not only with America, but with its allies as well. Moreover, many militant outfits that continued to prioritize other enemies experienced a hybridization, whereby they began including America and its allies among their list of adversaries to be fought. Today, the term global jihad is used to describe the jihad against America and its allies as well as the nexus of actors who participate in that jihad.

The concept of jihad as religiously sanctioned war to protect the umma has a strong historical tradition in South Asia.[6] Successive governments in Pakistan have tapped into this tradition since Partition to support the use of militant proxies who were declared mujahideen and lauded for waging legitimate jihads abroad, at times fighting alongside active-duty soldiers.